the northeast during World War II, would say in his book, *Defeat into Victory*: ‘In my experience it is not so much asking men to fight or work with obsolete equipment that lowers morale but the belief that those responsible are accepting such a state of affairs. If men realise that every one above them and behind them is flat out to get the things required for them, they will do wonders, as my men did, with meagre resources they have instead of sitting down moaning for better.’

The key was in Niranjan Prasad and John Dalvi’s hands, but the two officers failed to rise to the occasion. Both have since written books putting the entire blame on Kaul who, as we know, gave specific orders not to abandon the positions on the river, regardless of their tactical unsuitability. After the events of 10 October, when the Chinese demonstrated their intention by opening fire, both these officers needed to seize the moment and give their defences some depth. There was simply no Plan A or Plan B, no thinning of the defences or fortification of Hathung-la. Instead, they did absolutely nothing, simply hoping and praying that the Chinese were bluffing.

The bluff had in fact been perpetuated by them. The plan to evict the Chinese from the Thagla Ridge had been drawn up by Dalvi, who subsequently claimed he put up the plan hoping it would be shot down for its sheer absurdity. The sudden appearance of Kaul on the scene as the corps commander and the exit of Umrao Singh had further complicated matters, and set the scene for the Nam Ka Chu tragedy even before the Chinese guns opened up on 20 October.

7 Brigade’s collapse was a sign of things to come. Both the commanding officers of 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers bolted (there simply is no other word for it), leaving their men to their fate. 1/9 GR abandoned their CO, an unheard of act on the field of battle, while Dalvi himself wandered around until his ordeal ended with his capture. The Chinese hypothesis that if you got behind the Indians they simply would not know what to do was more than amply demonstrated time and again. The PLA commanders also believed that the Indian deployment was not mutually supportive. They could therefore afford to bring overwhelming force against each Indian position and wipe them out one by one.

So focused was Niranjan Prasad on Nam Ka Chu, that the 5 Assam Rifles platoon and the 1 Sikh company at Bum-la were left more or less on their own to fight screening battles. Despite Bogey Sen’s presence on the